day, harrying her men to repair the wall while musket shots punctured the air all around her. The Mughals were repulsed, with Abdur Rahim, once again, being blamed for less than enthusiastic support for the army. ‘The end of the day,’ wrote a despairing Abu’l Fazl, ‘shone upon failure.’ In the end, an uneasy truce was agreed. In February 1596, Berar was ceded to Murad’s forces and Chand Sultan’s protégé, Bahadur, was recognized as nizam ul-mulk though he had to accept Mughal suzerainty.

At Akbar’s court at Lahore, the truce was deemed to be a shameful defeat. Prince Murad’s mighty Mughal forces had been defeated by what would have been considered a paltry and inconsequential party. Murad certainly seemed to have viewed the failure to take Ahmadnagar as a grievous personal failure. From now on, despite insistent orders from an increasingly worried Akbar to return to court, Murad would succumb to drink and would refuse all contact with the court or its ambassadors.

While these complicated Mughal calculations were playing out in the Deccan, further north, in what had been the badlands of Hindustan, Bir Singh Deo was resisting the path that fate had ordered for him. A later portrait of Bir Singh Deo shows us a somewhat roguish man looking ill at ease in the fine diaphanous jama of a Mughal courtier. As only the sixth son of Madhukar Shah of Orchha, his was to have been an unremarkable life, but when Ram Shah, the eldest son, inherited the throne upon the death of his father in 1592, Bir Singh Deo refused to submit to his brother. Now the old ways of succession and rule had become complicated by the new Mughal reality. As Orchha was part of the Mughal Empire, the claimants to the throne had to contend with the tumultuous world of Mughal politics. Bir Singh Deo skirmished with the forces of his brother and the Mughals throughout the 1590s. But now the Mughal Padshah was no longer the only source of imperial power, there was also Salim, and the paths of these two, impatient, and tempestuous princes—Bir Singh Deo and Mirza Salim—would cross, and they would forge a pact sealed in blood.

The volatile ambitions of all these princes, his three sons in addition to Bir Singh Deo, would finally take Akbar away from his northern capital. He would leave Lahore, never to return, for a precarious game of imperial politics was about to be played out as a new century dawned on the horizon of Mughal Hindustan.